

PUNCTUATION MARKS



Consider following sentences:

1. Let us eat, teacher.
2. Let us eat teacher.

Punctuation and meaning

Speakers use tone of voice to shape meaning.
Writers use punctuation marks.

It's not there.

It's not there!

It's not there?

Academic Writing

Good academic writing should be accurate. You need to clearly express its contents and always check for:

- **Punctuation.**
- **Spelling.**
- **Grammar (verb tenses, agreement, etc.)**

Punctuation

Punctuation marks are symbols used to:

1. organize the structure of written language, and
2. to indicate intonation (rise and fall/or speech pattern) and pauses to be observed when reading aloud.

It makes our Writing Clear and Easy to Read

For example,

“woman, without her man, is nothing”

it has a different meaning from

“woman: without her, man is nothing”

1. Full stop , or period (.)

Used at the end of a sentence:

- ❖ Kabul is the capital of Afghanistan.
- ❖ Many students study English.
- ❖ My brother lives in Mazar-e-Sharif.
- ❖ A flower grows.
- ❖ He stood up and went away.
- ❖ He was angry.

Used for abbreviations:

- ❖ Co. = (Company)
- ❖ M. P. = (Member of Parliament)

2. Question marks (?)

Question marks are used at the end of direct questions:

- ❖ What's your name?
- ❖ Do you like school?
- ❖ Where do you live?
- ❖ Did you do the homework?

Use a question mark at the end of tag questions:

- ❖ You will help me, won't you?
- ❖ He likes football, doesn't he?

3. Exclamation marks (!)

Use ! to show:

strong feeling

surprise

excitement

- ❖ The house is so beautiful!
- ❖ What a nice car!
- ❖ How interesting!
- ❖ Help!
- ❖ That's fantastic!

Used after interjections:

- ❖ Oh! It's awful.
- ❖ Ops! What's up?

3. Commas (,)

use commas for listing and joining 2 sentences together.

E.g

- ❖ Afghan students study English, Dari, Pashto, and computer skills.
- ❖ My friends names are Ahmad, Sardar and Jawad.
- ❖ I bought books, pens, and notebooks.
- ❖ After an introductory word or phrase

In the morning, I usually study.

Between two independent ideas joined by and, but, or so

E.g

- ❖ You must hand in your essay by Friday, or you will receive a mark of zero.
- ❖ I wanted to study, **but** I was tired.

4. Colons (:)

Colon can be used to introduce a list, extended quotation and introduce an explanation of a statement.

Introduce List/Examples

E.g

- ❖ Here are some chocolate bars: Mars bar, milky way and snicker.
- ❖ He visited three cities last year, for example: Kabul, Herat and Parwan.

Introduce Quotation

E.g

- ❖ Ahmad said to his mother: “Can I have some popcorn, please?. ”
- ❖ He said: “Your brother is on the phone.”

Explanation of a statement

E.g

- ❖ A lion: large, land based feline predator situated in a pride.
- ❖ He had one idea in his mind: to see his father as soon as possible.

4. Colons (:)

Cont'd

Colon can be used to introduce a list, extended quotation and introduce an explanation of a statement.

Separate independent clauses

E.g

❖ They will not make it home in time: the roads are vey icy.

Show Emphasis

E.g

❖ You have two choices: finish your HW or get into trouble.

5. Semi colon ;

It is used to join two complete sentences into a single written sentence without using conjunction like 'and'..

E,g

- ❖ Pass Ahmad his pencil case; it belongs to him.
- ❖ They woke up early; they went jogging.
- ❖ Ahmad loves to read books; he reads a new book everyday.

6. Quotation marks “”

A pair of quotation marks encloses a direct quotation.

Examples:

- ❖ “Do you like fishing?”
- ❖ “Do you have a book?”
- ❖ “What's your favourite subject?”
- ❖ “Do you play soccer?”

7. Hyphen -

is used to join two or more words together into a compound term and is not separated by spaces.

Examples:

- ❖ **part-time, back-to-back,**
- ❖ **well-known.**

8. Dash —

is used to separate parts of a sentence.

Examples:

- ❖ He gave him his answer — No!
- ❖ Ahmad can't wait for Eid — he's very excited.

9. Brackets []

used for technical explanations or to clarify meaning. If you remove the information in the brackets, the sentence will still make sense.

Examples:

- ❖ He [Mr. Mohammadi] was the last person seen at the house.
- ❖ She wrote, “We will arrive at 9:00 [in the morning].”

10. Apostrophe ‘

1. Showing possession

To indicate that something belongs to someone/something.

Singular noun + 's → *the boy's book* (the book of the boy) Ahmad's book

Plural noun ending in s + ' → *the students' classroom* (the classroom of the students)

Plural noun not ending in s + 's → *the children's toys*

2. Forming contractions

To show missing letters when two words are combined.

do not → *don't*

I am → *I'm*

they are → *they're*

3. Plurals of letters, numbers, and symbols (less common, mostly in informal or older style)

Mind your p's and q's.

He got all A's on his report card.

11. Ellipses

An **ellipsis** is a set of three dots (...) used in writing. It has several purposes:

1. Showing omission (leaving words out)

Often used when quoting someone but leaving out unnecessary words.

Original: “*Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world.*”

With ellipsis: “*Education is the most powerful weapon ... to change the world.*”

2. Showing hesitation or pause in speech

“Well ... I’m not really sure.”

“So ... what do you think?”

3. Showing unfinished thought or trailing off

“I thought I saw something, but ...”

“If only I had said ...”

12. Slash

1. Showing alternatives (choice)

You can write **and/or**.

Please press **on/off**.

Bring your **passport/ID**.

3. In dates

30/08/2025 (day/month/year)

08/30/2025 (month/day/year, American style)

4. Abbreviations

w/o = without

c/o = care of

n/a = not applicable

Now its your turn

Complete the following:

- ⦿ I went to the park
- ⦿ Do you like cats
- ⦿ Help
- ⦿ I like fruit especially apples raspberries and strawberries
- ⦿ Pass Ahmad his school bag it belongs to him
- ⦿ i like eating pizza and ice cream
- ⦿ Ahmad asked his friend are you coming to my party
- ⦿ That's fantastic

Answers

- ◎ I went to the park.
- ◎ Do you like cats?
- ◎ Help!
- ◎ I like fruit especially apples, raspberries and strawberries.
- ◎ Pass Ahmad his school bag; it belongs to him.
- ◎ I like eating pizza and ice cream.
- ◎ Ahmad asked his friend “Are you coming to my party?”
- ◎ That's fantastic!

Capital Letters

Use capital letters to start a sentence, languages, days of the week, months and names of countries, your name beginning of quotations.

Sentence e.g.

Learn the names of countries.

Languages e.g

Julie speaks English, French and German.

Days of the week

I love Mondays.

Months

Emma's birthday is in March.

Countries

It is hot in China.

Name

My name is Luke.

Quotations

“What's your favourite colour?”